

is ready to focus on the brasstacks of serious exchange of ideas, an NG is the place to be. A news-reader that can make the process of finding compatible NGs easy, and handle the



The Thunderbird interface

basic functions of reading and replying to messages is a valuable tool. While standalone apps exist, whether your needs are met by an extant e-mail client or even by sites that allow NG access needs to be evaluated before proceeding. The only real need to have a standalone app seems to be when dealing with binaries.

7.2 RSS Feed Readers

7.2.1 Introduction

Syndication is, simply put, the practice of offering content to publishers. This is commonly seen as cartoon strips in newspapers, where the artist syndicates his work to newspaper publishers. More than one newspaper can carry the same syndicated cartoon on the same day. The online version of syndication works on similar lines: someone who creates content—like news sites or bloggers—allows the content to be passed on to those who would like to publish it on their site, or just be informed of new posts.

The message that is sent out is called a feed, which besides the core content of the creator also contains meta information. There are mainly two formats in which the feed is structured—RSS and Atom, both of which are based on the XML file format. RSS or Really Simple Syndication (or Rich Site Summary) is the more commonly used format (there are different versions of RSS including one called RDF) and it is common to refer to a feed as an RSS feed even though it may be an Atom feed.

To be able to display the feed, one needs an application that can recognise the main formats. A standalone application is called